the Nepalese intention since they were courting India's adversaries, China and Pakistan. Due to the unwillingness of the Indian government, the R&AW lost the opportunity to recruit and run top rung leaders who could have provided state secrets. There is no substitute for human intelligence collection and if the sources are drying up, the job of accurate prediction is nearly impossible. The government expressed doubts over the Maoists' intentions but we wanted our men everywhere. It can be dangerous to not have sniffers in the enemy camp.

We continue to run our well-placed sources inside Nepal with proper control. Even when the use was limited—since it is always up to the government to decide how far we want to go — we recruited more informers to track every step the Nepalese decision makers were taking. Handling agents is very difficult in such a hostile environment, but we cannot afford to be surprised. Our security concern was the Terai region and certain areas in Kathmandu since militants were setting up camps and safe houses close to the border and a renewed operation was launched to eliminate the radicals while the government continued to placate Nepalese politicians with aid for development and infrastructure projects.'

According to Khatri, political and diplomatic manoeuvring is for short-term benefits but espionage will give you long-term stability. 'Even today, the Nepalese government argues that India is a more vital and important neighbour than China, but you cannot blindly trust their words. The days of winning hearts are over. It is time to weaken anti-India elements. The priority is clear—we support an elected, stable and democratic government free from Chinese and Pakistani control.'